Rs 42.20 lakh crore, while government consumption is expected to register a small increase from Rs 15.4 lakh crore to Rs 15.9 trillion.

The Brahmastra Boomeranged: India Locked Down Lock, Stock and Barrel

India was not in the pink of economic health in 2019–20. Yet, by an impulsive decision, the country was placed under a twenty-one-day lockdown, without any notice or warning, on 24 March 2020 which locked up 135 crore Indians in their homes, or wherever they were stranded that evening.

Having originated in China in December 2019, the COVID-19 virus spread swiftly to all parts of the world in the next three months. In March, India had the benefit of knowing how it was effectively handled in China and South Korea and how badly it was handled in Italy and Iran. A localized total lockdown in areas where the virus had spread, to cut off contact between the infected (symptomatic or asymptomatic) and the uninfected outside the local zone, was the master key to stop the virus in its tracks. However, India decided to lock up the entire country, all its businesses and all its people.

Millions of businesses producing goods and services barring essential services were locked down and knocked down. Over 12 crore workers were rendered jobless overnight; many started walking hundreds of kilometres, as all means of transportation were also stopped, to the safety of their rural homes. The lockdown was imposed with a naive belief that India would be able to eliminate the virus in three weeks' time.

India's lockdown strategy was clearly faulty. A total economic, social and human lockdown is like the Brahmastra, the most lethal and devastating weapon. It has to be exercised with enormous care and applied with the complete precision of a nuclear option. However, India decided to use this weapon on the entire country when only tiny parts of the country (areas